

**Google employees quit over drone**

A dozen Google employees quit over a military drone project when the company decided to go ahead with it. <https://digit.in/jun18-A48-1>

**New Concrete formula developed**

University of Michigan researchers have developed a new concrete type for cheaper, durable roads. <https://digit.in/jun18-A48-2>

Supercharge your voice assistant

Voice assistants are constantly reinventing and bettering themselves over the years, however, they are not capable of doing everything we'd expect most times. Here's how you can possibly get past those hiccups.

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oice assistants, be it in your smart home devices or smart-phones, are the new, contemporary

commodities that are being constantly evolved and furthered to aid the smoothest user experience.

The evolution over the years is commendable in most instances, and marvelous in others. Despite this, there are features and actions that every voice assistant platform lacks. Siri and Bixby have often seen the brunt of users for not being intuitive or 'smart' enough. Google Assistant still has areas of deficiency. Alexa is quite functional and but it lacks conversability.

Most users hate the fact that none of the voice assistants can do it all in 2018. Fortunately, there are apps and actions that can 'supercharge' your voice assistants and inject some of the absent functionality into them.

**GOOGLE ASSISTANT**

Google Assistant has made considerable strides since its inception and is considered one of the most well-rounded voice assistants, many even consider it to be the best of the lot. And now, Google Assistant can utilize a third-party app called IFTTT, short for 'If This, Then That', a web-based tool that allows the user to connect the functionality of different apps through their premade 'applets' or triggers. There's a plethora of functionalities that the Assistant can avail through this robust, third-party app. It is downloadable for free on Android (<https://digit.in/IFTTAndroid>) and iOS (<https://digit.in/IFTTiOS>).

Connect IFTTT via the Google Assistant linking on the app or website and you're good to go. You have the power to equip Google Assistant with a bunch of features and customisable functionalities that are not achievable on it yet. You can even custom create applets on the IFTTT platform and unleash those creative juices into making other users' lives, and your own, easier.

For instance, Google Assistant is capable of making calls and sending text messages to contacts, so it is a bummer that it cannot create contacts. IFTTT connects the Google Assistant to Google Contacts and uses the applet to make this useful little function possible. It can also enable taking notes directly to a Google Drive spreadsheet. The spreadsheet will be saved in the Google/Assistant notes folder in your Google Drive by default. Each note

you add by using the custom note command created on IFTTT will be saved as a new row in the spreadsheet. Through IFTTT, Google Assistant can also act as your secretary by compiling a daily-to-do-list and sending it to your email ID. The list can be sent to multiple people and posted to apps like Evernote, Slack or Trello as well. Another neat little trick is being able to post a Facebook status, Twitter update and LinkedIn update as well.

IFTTT also lets Google Assistant perform advanced actions like turning your TV on and off (if your TV uses Logitech's Harmony series of universal remotes), find your phone (although, Device Manager

does it better) and even control your Philips Hue lights. IFTTT doesn't ignore users on iPhones using or wanting to use Google Assistant and allows functions like adding reminders to your iPhone through Google Assistant and integrating Apple Calendar with Assistant and Google Home.

**ALEXA**

Alexa is the voice assistant that is housed inside Amazon's smart speakers. Alexa is extremely capable in its own category, where it plays a pivotal role in a 'smart' connected home. It performs functions like music playback, creating to-do-lists, setting alarms, streaming podcasts and can effectively give weather, traffic and more real-time information. Amazon opened Alexa's software to third-party developers which has allowed support